

Patrolling the Powerful: The Reputational Consequences of Punishing Power-holders

Abstract

Power-holders have a disproportionate capacity to harm others, yet people are often reluctant to punish them. Consistent with this view, existing research has focused primarily on the higher *costs* associated with punishing higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators. We offer a contrasting perspective, showing that alongside these higher costs, punishing power-holders also yields greater reputational *benefits*. Drawing on costly signaling theory, we propose that third-party punishment of higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators functions as a more diagnostic signal of moral character, leading observers to confer enhanced social rewards on these punishers. Across five preregistered experiments (total $N = 3,210$ participants), individuals who third-party punished higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators were judged to possess higher moral character – and, in turn, they received greater status, financial resources, trust, and partner selection. Together, these findings reveal a dual cost-benefit structure of punishment in hierarchical contexts and help explain how social groups may motivate the punishment of unethical power-holders.

Public Significance Statement

Unethical behavior by powerful individuals can cause serious harm, yet people may be reluctant to challenge those in positions of authority. This research shows that when people do challenge powerful wrongdoers, they are seen as being highly moral and receive social benefits such as greater trust, support, and status. These findings suggest that social rewards may encourage people to challenge the powerful when they behave unethically.

Keywords: third-party punishment, power, moral character

Unethical behavior is a damaging and pervasive feature of social life (Andersson & Pearson, 1999; Marcus & Schuler, 2004; Robinson & Bennett, 1995). Individuals commit a range of transgressions, including harassment, breaches of confidentiality, and lying, to name a few. Although such behavior occurs across levels of social hierarchy, its consequences are especially severe when it is committed by those who hold power. Not only are individuals more likely to commit unethical acts when they gain power, but these acts can also have more costly implications (Lammers et al., 2015; Maner & Mead, 2010). Recent scandals provide vivid indications of this. For example, Harvey Weinstein used his power to sexually assault numerous aspiring actors (Kantor & Twohey, 2019). Although many people were aware of Weinstein's unethical behavior early on, few spoke up (Tsui, 2018), enabling his abuse to persist for decades. Identifying how social groups can prevent, or at least curtail, power-holders' unethical behavior therefore represents a pressing theoretical and practical challenge.

An effective way of reducing unethical behavior is through punishment (Balliet et al., 2011; Fehr & Gächter, 2002; Sarin et al., 2021). Although formal systems, such as policing and the judicial system, are in place to punish unethical perpetrators (Wylie et al., 2025), punishment often occurs through informal mechanisms in everyday life (Molho et al., 2020). One particularly effective means involves directly confronting perpetrators. This form of punishment has been investigated across various areas of psychology – including social, moral, cognitive, applied, and evolutionary psychology – using a variety of terms, including third-party punishment, ethical voice, accusation, and moral rebellion (e.g., Chen & Treviño, 2023; Dhaliwal et al., 2021; Gordon et al., 2014; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Martin et al., 2019; Molho et al., 2020; Monin et al., 2008; Rattan & Dweck, 2010; Wellman et al., 2016). Punishing perpetrators in this way efficiently interrupts unethical behavior and discourages its repetition, preventing it from

becoming normalized (Ashforth & Anand, 2003; Sarin et al., 2021), and helping to protect targets by reducing the likelihood of them suffering further harm (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Cortina & Magley, 2003; Czopp et al., 2006; Parker et al., 2018).

Unfortunately, individuals' willingness to punish is inhibited by the costs they face (Detert & Edmondson, 2011; Milliken et al., 2003; Nikiforakis & Engelmann, 2011). Perpetrators and even other social group members may retaliate against punishers (Milgram, 1965; Monin et al., 2008; Morrison, 2011) and in anticipation, punishers may experience fear and anxiety over the possible consequences (Adams & Mullen, 2012; Kish-Gephart et al., 2009). These costs intensify when punishers have less power than perpetrators – because higher-power perpetrators can inflict particularly strong retaliatory costs on lower-power punishers (Cortina & Magley, 2003), and compliant audiences react negatively to punishers in lower-power roles (Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Gulker et al., 2013; Wellman et al., 2016).

In sum, the literature has painted a pessimistic picture: individuals may be least likely to punish the very people with the most capacity to cause harm. At the same time, there is evidence that individuals *do* at times punish higher-power perpetrators, even when these punishers are not victims of their misdeeds. For example, recent data reveal that, among United States civil servants who witness unethical behavior committed by their supervisors at work, almost 25% directly confront them (see *Supplemental Study 1*). This poses an interesting question – why might these otherwise-uninvolved individuals step in to punish powerful perpetrators, despite the seemingly prohibitive costs?

In the present research, we investigate the possibility that, in parallel to the pessimistic dynamic outlined in extant literature, a more positive one exists. Specifically, we adopt a socio-cognitive framework to predict that observers offer superior reputational rewards to uninvolved

third parties who punish higher-power perpetrators. Drawing on costly signaling theory (Zahavi & Zahavi, 1999), we propose that the greater costs involved in third-party punishing higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators serve as a more reliable signal of punishers' moral character. As a result, those who punish higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators are likely to be conferred higher moral character. Importantly, we propose that elevated reputations for moral character lead to consequential social and financial rewards. If true, then this suggests a previously unidentified reward system that may incentivize individuals to punish higher-power perpetrators.

At its core, our work is concerned with the important issue of how hierarchical social groups respond to powerful people who do wrong. We draw upon theories and topics from various areas of psychology to uncover a set of findings that are of broad theoretical interest and relevance. Our particular focus here is not so much on the punishers, but on the broader dynamic of how people respond to punishers. In doing so, we begin to uncover the wider group processes that may contribute to the patrolling of the powerful.

Punishment as a prosocial behavior

Punishment takes place in every human society (Henrich et al., 2006). Although punishment can be meted out formally through the rule of law or institutions (e.g., disciplinary procedures), it most often unfolds informally in social groups (Molho et al., 2020). A person who behaves unethically may be directly approached by another individual who expresses their disapproval (i.e., direct punishment) or the perpetrator may become the source of negative gossip or ostracism (i.e., indirect punishment)¹. Although indirect punishment reduces unethical

¹ In laboratory settings, punishment is often operationalized through financial sanctions: the punisher pays to reduce the perpetrator's endowment (e.g., Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004). Although this method has many advantages, it may

behavior (Feinberg et al., 2014), it is slower than direct punishment and relies on effective communication across multiple group members (Molho et al., 2020).

Direct punishment, in contrast, is faster and more effective in changing behavior. One common form of direct punishment, verbal confrontation, occurs when an individual expresses disapproval to the perpetrator of an unethical act² (Czopp & Monteith, 2003). Confrontation reduces the likelihood that perpetrators reoffend by signaling the confronter's disapproval (Sarin et al., 2021), and eliciting feelings of guilt (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Czopp et al., 2006; Parker et al., 2018).

Whereas some research focuses on punishment by victims (e.g., Cortina & Magley, 2003; Raj & Wiltermuth, 2022), a great deal focuses on third-party punishment, where an uninvolved third-party punishes a perpetrator (e.g., Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Molho et al., 2020; Monin et al., 2008). Examples of this include confronting someone for harassing others, reprimanding someone who inappropriately discloses private information, and challenging a colleague taking credit for another's work³. Third-party punishment is a particularly interesting form of punishment because it is common and effective for groups, yet disadvantageous for punishers, who face considerable costs (Fehr & Gächter, 2002) but enjoy no direct benefits (cf. Rattan et al., 2023). In terms of costs, punishers expend time and resources (Pedersen et al., 2020) and they incur risks of retaliation by both perpetrators (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Gordon & Lea, 2016; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018) and compliant audiences (Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Monin et al., 2008). Punishers also face emotional costs, including distress

introduce demand effects that overstate the frequency of punishment (Pedersen et al., 2018), while punishment in naturalistic social groups tends to unfold through social sanctions (Molho et al., 2020).

² Direct punishment can also include physical confrontation, but this is rare in most social contexts (Molho et al., 2020), therefore we focus on verbal confrontation.

³ These examples are taken from real accounts provided by participants in Experiment 1.

for putting relationships with perpetrators at risk, and anxiety over retaliation (Adams & Mullen, 2012; Kish-Gephart et al., 2009). Yet the benefits of punishment flow to victims or to groups rather than to punishers. Third-party punishment therefore represents a prosocial behavior – costly to the actor and intended to benefit others (Batson & Powell, 2003).

The unattractive cost-benefit for third-party punishment begs the question: why would anyone punish when they are not direct victims of unethical behavior? One answer is that punishment helps individuals develop stronger moral reputations, which offer downstream benefits for punishers (Jordan et al., 2016; Nelissen, 2008).

Third-party punishment provides a costly signal of moral character

Costly signaling theory (Zahavi & Zahavi, 1999) proposes that when individuals engage in behaviors that are costly or difficult to perform, they signal that they possess advantageous but otherwise hidden traits. In third-party punishment, greater costliness provides a more reliable signal that the actor possesses high moral character – a valuable, but unobservable trait. Various findings support this dynamic: people who spend more financial resources to punish are seen as having higher moral character (Dhaliwal et al., 2021; Nelissen, 2008) and are judged as being more trustworthy, group-concerned, and respectable (Li et al., 2021). In the following section, we theorize about how this dynamic plays out in hierarchical social groups, where perpetrators may hold higher- or lower-power roles compared to punishers.

Third-party punishing power-holders is a costly signal of moral character

Power, defined as access to and control over valuable resources, permeates social life (Emerson, 1962; Magee & Galinsky, 2008). It is an inherently relative construct – one person has more power than another on a particular dimension. In research teams, for instance, tenured professors hold power over graduate students by controlling access to funding (Anicich et al.,

2022). In romantic relationships, one partner may have more power through unequal income, although power dynamics can shift when considering other dimensions, e.g., access to valued social networks (Gruenfeld et al., 2008; Righetti et al., 2015).

Power enables people to influence others by granting or restricting access to valuable resources (Galinsky et al., 2008). For example, higher-power perpetrators can disincentivize punishment by exacting more costly retaliation on those who punish them, including negative performance evaluations or group ostracism (see *Supplemental Study 1*). The threat of retaliation by power-holders also heightens anxiety and worry, adding psychological cost (Adams & Mullen, 2012; Kish-Gephart et al., 2009). These potential costs discourage people from punishing higher-power perpetrators (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Molho et al., 2020), even though their wrongdoings elicit widespread moral condemnation (Fragale et al., 2009; Reyes-Jaquez & Koenig, 2021), particularly when these individuals are highly dominant (Kakkar et al., 2020) and they commit serious wrongdoings (Karelaia & Keck, 2013).

In the present research, we suggest that audiences are also aware of the elevated costs of punishing higher-power perpetrators. We also build on existing research showing that audiences thoughtfully consider power relationships to make moral inferences about prosocial behavior (Inesi et al., 2021; Jones, 1964). Thus, pulling together disparate research on third-party punishment, costly signaling theory and power, we propose that, because audiences infer that punishers face greater costs when they punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators, they ascribe them higher moral character.

Reputational rewards for third-party punishing higher-power perpetrators

Importantly, reputations for high moral character yield downstream benefits. People with highly moral reputations receive concrete resources – social and financial – even from those who

are not beneficiaries of their acts. Below, we propose that third-party punishers who are seen as having higher moral character will enjoy higher status (Bai et al., 2020; Flynn, 2003; Hardy & Van Vugt, 2006), increased financial rewards (Nelissen, 2008; Raihani & Bshary, 2015), will be trusted more (Jordan et al., 2016), and will be more likely to be chosen as interaction partners (Nelissen, 2008).

Status. Status, defined as respect and admiration from others (Magee & Galinsky, 2008), has drawn decades of scholarly attention because of its vital role in fulfilling individuals' needs, shaping their behaviors and determining the outcomes they achieve (Anderson et al., 2015; Magee & Galinsky, 2008). In social groups, those with higher status receive more opportunities to exert influence and more positive evaluations (Correll & Ridgeway, 2006). Status is conferred upon individuals with attributes that aid in achieving a group's objectives (Anderson et al., 2015; Magee & Galinsky, 2008). Moral character is one such attribute, signaling willingness to subsume individual interests for the group. Thus, generous group members (Flynn, 2003; Hardy & Van Vugt, 2006) and those seen as morally virtuous (Bai et al., 2020) achieve higher status. We predict that those who punish higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators will be granted more status because they are seen as having higher moral character.

Indirect reciprocity. Indirect reciprocity is the process by which a prosocial actor receives resources from individuals who have not directly benefited from their acts (Alexander, 2017; Nowak & Sigmund, 2005). It is a rewards system based on reputation, providing resources such as helping, money, or social support for individuals with moral reputations (Wu et al., 2016). Accordingly, it is different and broader than direct reciprocity (Trivers, 1971), where rewards are offered by direct beneficiaries. Building on our earlier theorizing that audiences

confer higher moral character on those who punish higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators, we predict that this will drive up the indirect reciprocity they receive.

Trust. Earning the trust of others is critical for social outcomes in groups (Balliet & Van Lange, 2013; Delgado et al., 2005). Individuals with reputations for high moral character enjoy greater trust from others (Delgado et al., 2005) – and punishment fosters trust, since it signals integrity (Jordan et al., 2016; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018). Building on our prediction that individuals who punish higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators earn stronger reputations for moral character, we suggest that this will lead them to be trusted more.

Partner selection. In social groups, individuals compete with one another to be selected as interaction partners (Roberts et al., 2021). Research has shown that prosocial actors are more likely to be selected because they are seen as having higher moral character (Barclay & Willer, 2007; Dhaliwal et al., 2022; Hardy & Van Vugt, 2006; Van Vugt et al., 2007). Thus, we predict that individuals who punish higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators will be more likely to be selected as interaction partners because they are seen as having higher moral character.

Overview of the Present Research

Across five experiments, we examine the reputational consequences of third-party punishing higher- versus lower-power perpetrators of unethical behavior. Our experiments leverage organizational contexts, where there is a primary dimension of power – organizational hierarchy – which is widely known and relatively stable, due to formal roles and structures. Individuals higher in the organizational hierarchy control the income, promotions, and continued employment of those lower down, and thus have greater power. We operationalize third-party punishment through the verbal confrontation of perpetrators, which is a common (Molho et al.,

2020) and effective (Sarin et al., 2021) form of punishment that has been widely used in the literature (e.g., Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Martin et al., 2019; Monin et al., 2008).

In Experiment 1, we use the critical incident technique (Flanagan, 1954) to collate 700 real experiences of third-party punishment. We then randomly assign an independent sample of individuals to rate the moral character of these punishers. In Experiment 2, we survey participants to understand whether a person's relative willingness to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators predicts status. In Experiment 3, we use a controlled experiment to isolate the causal nature of our proposed effect, and we examine boundary conditions, specifically whether the effect of power on moral character is moderated by immediacy and level of visibility (public/private) of the punishment. Lastly, in Experiments 4a and 4b, we explore rewards that spring from reputations for high moral character: indirect reciprocity, trust, and partner selection. Cell means are presented in Table 1. We also provide three additional studies in our *Supplemental Materials*, two of which were pre-registered.

Table 1

Cell means across experiments (standard deviations in parentheses)

	Experiment 1	Experiment 3 ^a	Experiment 4a	Experiment 4b
<i>Costs</i>				
Lower-power perpetrator	-	-	-	2.93 (1.05)
Higher-power perpetrator	-	-	-	3.53 (0.84)
<i>Moral Character</i>				
Lower-power perpetrator	4.75 (1.30)	6.65 (1.71)	5.36 (1.11)	6.96 (1.44)
Higher-power perpetrator	5.26 (1.26)	7.37 (1.54)	5.72 (1.03)	7.63 (1.11)
<i>Indirect Reciprocity</i>				
Lower-power perpetrator	-	-	13.38 (14.57)	-
Higher-power perpetrator	-	-	16.15 (16.43)	-
<i>Trust</i>				
Lower-power perpetrator	-	-	-	20.78 (10.42)
Higher-power perpetrator	-	-	-	21.74 (9.29)
<i>Partner Selection</i>				
Lower-power perpetrator	-	-	-	5.18 (1.76)
Higher-power perpetrator	-	-	-	5.54 (1.54)

Note: (a) Means for Experiment 3 collapsed across punishment conditions.

Transparency and Openness

All experiments in this manuscript were preregistered (Experiment 1 at https://aspredicted.org/R3Y_NRT; Experiment 2 at https://aspredicted.org/HD6_L3B; Experiment 3 at <https://aspredicted.org/3vgy-bd3y.pdf>; Experiment 4a at https://aspredicted.org/4CZ_MR2; Experiment 4b at <https://aspredicted.org/78qv-s8dx.pdf>). For each experiment, we report how we determined our sample size, data exclusions, manipulations and measures in the main text, and we follow Journal Article Reporting Standards (Kazak, 2018). We analyzed data using R Version 4.5.1 (R Core Team, 2025) and several open-source

packages (see *Supplemental Materials*). Materials for our experiments, anonymized data and syntax to replicate our results are publicly accessible on the Open Science Framework at:

https://osf.io/285xg/?view_only=ebe6c4af1b9a499d974dec0df9cae55f.

Experiment 1

Experiment 1 provides an externally valid test of our core prediction that punishers are seen as having higher moral character when they punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators. Drawing on the critical incident technique (Flanagan, 1954), we asked a large and diverse sample of employees from organizations in the United Kingdom to recall a workplace interaction in which they confronted an unethical colleague. We randomly allocated participants to describe punishing either a higher- or lower-power colleague. We were able to recruit a diverse sample of adults from numerous industries and organizations, which enabled us to create a rich catalogue of punishment stories to improve the generalizability of our findings. After collecting stories, we asked other working adults to judge these punishers' moral character. We predicted that participants who described punishing higher-power colleagues would be ascribed greater moral character than those who described punishing lower-power colleagues.

Method

Participants

We predicted to uncover a small effect of power on moral character (Cohen's $d = 0.20$) based on a small pilot experiment. We used this expectation in a power analysis on G*Power (Faul et al., 2009), and found that a sample of $N = 620$ was appropriate to ensure power of 0.80 at a significance level of 0.05. To be conservative and account for exclusions, we aimed to obtain stories of punishments from 700 working adults on Prolific, spread equally across two conditions: one in which the perpetrator had higher power relative to the punisher, and one in

which the perpetrator had lower power. We then planned to recruit a further 700 working adults to provide moral character ratings for the participants who provided these stories. We therefore sought to recruit a minimum of 1,400 participants in total.

Part 1. In Part 1, we over-recruited because we assumed some participants would not be able to provide a story of punishment. Therefore, we elicited stories from 1,103 working adults. As preregistered, we reviewed these stories and excluded participants that did not describe a time they acted as a third party who confronted a perpetrator. Specifically, one of our authors read each of these stories and excluded 396 participants [321 participants (47.3%) from the *higher*-power perpetrator condition and 75 participants (17.6%) from the *lower*-power perpetrator condition]⁴. In most cases, we excluded stories because the participant described confronting a perpetrator who had transgressed directly against them (164 participants in *higher*-power perpetrator condition; 20 participants in *lower*-power perpetrator condition). We also excluded stories where participants did not provide any story, provided a story involving a perpetrator in a different power relationship from the one requested, or did not describe the confrontation. Lastly, we excluded the final seven stories collected in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition, since we accidentally exceeded our target. We cut off recruiting for each condition when we reached enough usable stories, retaining 350 stories where the participant described confronting a higher-power perpetrator, and another 350 stories where the participant described confronting a lower-power perpetrator. All these stories are available in the *Supplemental Materials*, together with

⁴ Significantly fewer participants were able to recall a time in which they had confronted a higher- versus a lower-power perpetrator ($\chi^2 = 98.84$, $df = 1$, $p < .001$). 52.7% of participants in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition recalled a confrontation, versus 82.4% in the *lower*-power perpetrator condition. This difference could be driven by numerous factors, e.g., fewer unethical acts performed by higher- versus lower-power colleagues and thus fewer opportunities to confront, power-holders being more likely to detect ethical misconduct given their greater resources leading to greater confrontation occasions, or greater costs of confronting higher-power individuals discouraging observers from confronting them.

further details concerning the story selection process. These 700 participants (53.6% women, 46.0% men, 0.4% not disclosed) all reside and work in the United Kingdom, with an average age of 40.29 ($SD = 11.22$).

Part 2. In the second part of the experiment (Part 2), we recruited an independent set of participants to rate the moral character of the participants who provided stories in Part 1. Each Part 2 participant was yoked to exactly one Part 1 participant at random. In line with our preregistration, we excluded 292 participants who failed attention and comprehension checks in the exercise, and seven participants for not providing moral character ratings. After exclusions, the final dataset includes 712 participants (55.5% women, 44.0% men, 0.5% not disclosed)⁵, all of whom work and reside in the United Kingdom, with an average age of 40.41 ($SD = 11.59$). Participants were paid £0.50. We employed a 2-cell perpetrator power (*higher* versus *lower*) between-participant design.

Procedure

We asked participants in Part 1 to think about and then describe a past situation in which they confronted their supervisor (*higher*-power perpetrator condition) or a direct report (*lower*-power perpetrator condition) when that person showed unethical behavior. We prompted participants to describe the unethical act and the moment they confronted the perpetrator.

In Part 2, we informed participants that they would read one story written by a working adult, who confronted their supervisor (*higher*-power perpetrator condition) or direct report (*lower*-power perpetrator condition). After Part 2 participants read one story, we asked them to rate the moral character of the Part 1 story-provider.

⁵ A coding error meant that 128 stories were read and responded to by two participants, rather than just one as intended. Five additional stories were seen by three different Part 2 participants, rather than one as intended. We retained these observations in our analyses, however excluding them does not significantly impact findings.

Measures

Manipulation checks. Part 1 participants reported the relative amount of power that the person they punished had (1 = *Much less power than me*, 7 = *Much more power than me*). We asked Part 2 participants to rate the extent to which they agree that the storyteller had more power than the person they confronted (i.e., their supervisor or direct report) (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly agree*).

Moral character. We used a nine-item bipolar scale of moral character (including Awful-Nice, Dishonest-Honest, Cruel-Kind, Cold-Warm, Unfair-Fair, Immoral-Moral, Arrogant-Humble, Dislikable-Likable, Bad-Good; 7-point scale; subset of items focused on actor morality; Effron et al., 2015; $\alpha = 0.95$).

Results and Discussion

Manipulation checks

Part 1. An independent-samples t-test evaluating the effect of perpetrator power condition on perceived relative power between participant and perpetrator revealed a significant effect; $t(698) = 39.52, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 2.99$. As expected, participants perceived that the perpetrator had more power relative to them in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition ($M = 5.87, SD = 0.85$), compared to the *lower*-power perpetrator condition ($M = 2.64, SD = 1.27$).

Part 2. An independent-samples t-test evaluating the effect of perpetrator power condition on perceived relative power between the punisher and perpetrator revealed a significant effect; $t(710) = 20.19, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.53$. As expected, participants perceived that the punisher had more power relative to the perpetrator in the *lower*-power perpetrator condition ($M = 3.68, SD = 1.24$), compared to the *higher*-power perpetrator condition ($M = 2.00, SD = 0.97$).

Moral character

An independent-samples t-test on moral character revealed a main effect of perpetrator power condition; $t(710) = 5.24, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.40$. Consistent with our central prediction, participants perceived that punishers had higher moral character when they described punishing *higher-* ($M = 5.26, SD = 1.26$) versus *lower-*power perpetrators ($M = 4.75, SD = 1.30$)⁶. In supplemental analyses, we found that this effect was robust once we controlled for features of the stories, including the type of unethical behavior, whether the punishment took place in public or private, whether the punishment was immediate or delayed, and the length of the story provided ($b = 0.51, SE = 0.10, p < .001$). Refer to *Supplemental Materials* for further details.

Experiment 1 offers support for our core prediction – observers confer higher moral character on punishers who describe punishing higher- versus lower-power perpetrators. Notably, this effect emerged when working adults rated real stories of confrontations provided by other working adults, which naturally contained high variance in terms of the types of unethical behavior and confrontation context. Our supplemental analyses revealed that the effect of power on moral character ascriptions for punishers was robust even when controlling for features of the unethical behavior, audience, and timing. An additional noteworthy feature of this experiment is that most participants in Part 1 were able to generate examples from their work history in which they had punished, suggesting that third-party punishment is relatively common in the workplace.

⁶ This result was robust using an exploratory independent-samples t-test on a composite of the items most closely related to moral character (Goodwin et al., 2014); i.e., Dishonest-Honest, Unfair-Fair, Immoral-Moral, Bad-Good); $t(710) = 4.59, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.35$.

Experiment 2

Experiment 1 provided initial support for our central prediction using real examples of punishments. It also provided initial evidence of the causal role that power plays in the development of moral reputations. At the same time, participants read and responded to punishments by people they did not know. Although this mirrors processes by which gossip may enhance reputation (Feinberg et al., 2012, 2014), we sought support for our theory in the context of ongoing relationships. Thus, in Experiment 2, we asked participants to reflect upon punishments by people they know.

A second contribution of Experiment 2 is to consider social rewards that emerge from punishers' reputations. A core component of our theory is that power differences between punishers and perpetrators drive moral reputations. At the same time, moral reputations only translate into real benefits when they turn into social or material rewards. Status is a vital resource that allows for greater influence over groups (Magee & Galinsky, 2008). Therefore, in Experiment 2, we focus on status as our outcome.

We predicted that the *relative* propensity to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators would be positively correlated with status. We know from our supplemental data (see *Supplemental Study 1*) and existing research (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Molho et al., 2020) that people are more reticent to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators because doing so is more costly. However, as the difference in willingness to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators shrinks, this should positively reflect on the moral character of the punisher – i.e., even as costs rise, they remain willing to punish. In sum, we are not concerned with the general willingness to punish, but rather the *relative* willingness to punish higher-

versus lower-power perpetrators. Taken together, we predict that as relative willingness to punish a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator shrinks, the punisher earns higher status.

Method

Participants

We recruited 100 working adults from Prolific to participate in our experiment. We excluded four participants who failed an attention check and were directed out of the experiment before seeing the materials, in line with our preregistration. Therefore, after exclusions, the final dataset includes 96 working adults. 60.4% of participants were women and 39.6% were men. Participants were 35.33 years old on average ($SD = 9.52$). Participants were paid £0.50.

Procedure

We asked participants to provide the names of three colleagues with whom they currently work or had worked in the past. We then selected one of these colleagues at random to be the focal actor (i.e., the punisher) about whom participants responded to a series of further items. Specifically, we asked participants to rate how willing this colleague would be to punish a direct report and a supervisor who had done something morally wrong. We inserted the punisher's real name through the questions and randomized the order by which we presented these two items. Lastly, we asked participants how much status they conferred on the punisher.

We were conscious that both the power relationship between the respondent and the punisher, as well as the punisher's hierarchical role in the organization might exert independent effects on status. We sought to address this in two ways. First, we asked participants to list only supervisors in their three colleagues. That is, participants reported three past or present supervisors and we randomly picked one of those as the focal actor. Second, we measured the power that the punisher has in the organization and controlled for this in our analysis.

Measures

Relative propensity to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrator. We asked participants to rate the punisher's willingness to punish a supervisor and a direct report. For the higher-power punishment, we asked participants: "Imagine that [*name of punisher*] 's own supervisor were doing something morally wrong. To what extent do you think that [*name of punisher*] would be willing to confront this person?" In the lower-power punishment question, we replaced "own supervisor" with "one of [*name of punisher*] 's direct reports (someone that the [*name of punisher*] supervises)". Participants rated their agreement with this item on a 5-point scale (e.g., 1 = *Not at all willing*, 5 = *Extremely willing*).

From these items, we derived the relative propensity to punish a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator by taking the difference between these two scores ($M = -0.66$, $SD = 1.09$)⁷. This negative difference score indicated that participants reported that their colleagues would be less willing to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators; $t(95) = 5.88$, $p < .001$. This aligns with the greater costs of punishment and is consistent with the lower incidence rate of punishments involving higher- versus lower-power perpetrators that we found in Experiment 1 and *Supplemental Study 1*. Next, we derived the average propensity to punish perpetrators by taking the mean of these two items ($M = 3.92$, $SD = 0.97$), which we include in our regression model to control for punishers' general tendency to punish irrespective of perpetrator power.

Status. We asked participants how much status they conferred on the punisher using a two-item, face-valid scale, linked to the definition of status ("How much do you respect and

⁷ To aid interpretation of results and directly test our central prediction, we adjusted the preregistered model by using this difference score. Importantly, by including the average propensity to confront perpetrators as a covariate, this model is statistically equivalent to the preregistered specification in which status is regressed on the propensity to punish higher- and lower-power perpetrators.

admire [*name of punisher*]” and “How well-suited do you think [*name of punisher*] is for a position of high status at work”). Participants rated their agreement with both items on a 5-point scale (e.g., 1 = *Not at all*, 5 = *A great deal*). We found a high correlation in participants’ ratings for these two items ($r = 0.83, p < .001$) and thus combined them into a single status scale.

Controls. We asked participants how much power they believed the punisher has by asking “How much power does [*name of punisher*] have at work” (1 = *Very little power*, 7 = *A great deal of power*). As an additional control, we asked participants to evaluate their pre-existing relationship with the punisher by answering two items. These items were: “How well do you know [*name of punisher*]” and “How close are you to [*name of punisher*].” Items were rated on 1-5 scales (e.g., 1 = *Not at all well*, 5 = *Extremely well*). We found a high correlation in participants’ ratings for these two items ($r = 0.70, p < .001$) and thus combined them into a single scale.

Manipulation checks. We asked participants how much power they believed the punisher’s direct reports and own supervisor have at work (e.g., “How much power does [*name of punisher*]’s supervisor have at work?”) (7-point scale; 1 = *Very little power*, 7 = *A great deal of power*).

Results and Discussion

Means, standard deviations and correlations are presented in Table 2.

Table 2

Means, Standard Deviations and Correlations in Experiment 2

Variable	M	SD	1	2	3	4
1 Status	3.71	1.25				
2 Relative propensity to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrator	-0.66	1.09	0.42***			
3 Propensity to punish perpetrators	3.92	0.97	0.64***	0.27**		
4 Pre-existing relationship	2.65	0.98	0.61***	0.15	0.38***	
5 Colleague power	5.10	1.16	0.12	0.00	0.33**	0.08

Note. *M* = Mean, *SD* = Standard Deviation. *** $p < .001$. ** $p < .01$.

Manipulation checks

To evaluate whether participants perceived power differences as intended between the focal actor's direct reports and own supervisor, we conducted an independent-samples t-test on participants' power ratings of the focal actor's direct reports and own supervisor. Results revealed a significant difference in these power ratings; $t(190) = -9.06$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.31$. As expected, participants perceived that the focal actor's own supervisor had more power ($M = 5.86$, $SD = 1.37$) than that person's direct reports ($M = 4.08$, $SD = 1.35$).

Status

We regressed status on relative propensity to punish a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator (see Table 3). We also included three controls: average propensity to punish perpetrators, pre-existing relationship between the participant and the punisher and the absolute power of the punisher.

Table 3

Regression results predicting Status in Experiment 2

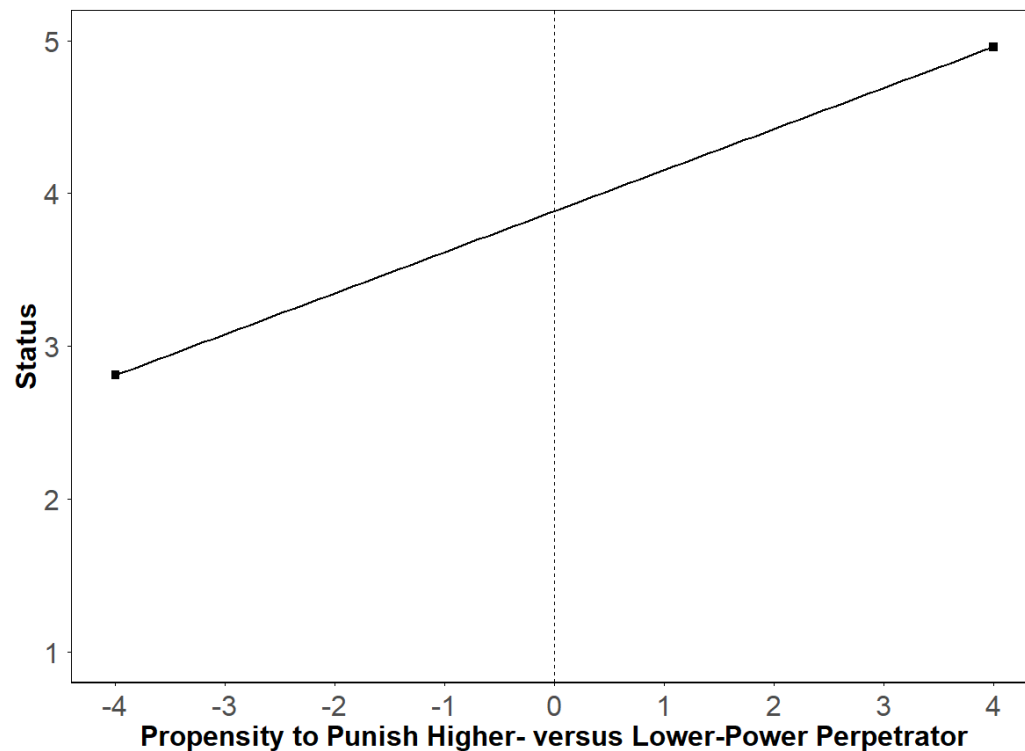
	b	SE	p
Intercept	0.61	0.46	.190
Relative propensity to punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrator	0.27***	0.08	.001
Propensity to punish perpetrators	0.56***	0.10	.000
Pre-existing relationship	0.53***	0.09	.000
Colleague power	-0.06	0.07	.425
R ²	0.62		
Adjusted R ²	0.60		
F (4, 91)	36.60, $p < .001$		

Note. *** $p < .001$.

We found that the propensity to punish a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator is positively associated with status ($b = 0.27$, $SE = 0.08$, $p < .001$). Thus, individuals are rewarded with greater status when their perceived willingness to punish a higher-power perpetrator of unethical behavior approaches or even surpasses their willingness to punish a lower-power perpetrator (see Figure 1).

Figure 1

The effect of propensity to punish a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator on status (Experiment 2)



We also found that individuals are conferred greater status as their average propensity to punish perpetrators increases ($b = 0.56$, $SE = 0.10$, $p < .001$). This latter finding replicates prior work that has found that punishers (versus non-punishers) earn greater reputational rewards from audiences (Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018). Lastly, we found that there was a positive association between status and the pre-existing relationship between participants and punishers ($b = 0.53$, $SE = 0.09$, $p < .001$), whereas – notably – the absolute level of power that the punisher had at work was not associated with their status ($b = -0.06$, $SE = 0.07$, $p = .425$).

Taken together, Experiments 1 and 2 provide evidence that punishing higher- versus lower-power perpetrators leads to stronger reputation for moral character and greater status.

Experiment 3

An important benefit of Experiments 1 and 2 is that they leverage real punishments (Experiment 1) and relationships (Experiment 2). At the same time, these methods raise the possibility that the identified effects are attributable to features of the punishments (Experiment 1) or relationships (Experiment 2). Therefore, Experiment 3 presents a single punishment scenario, and tests whether audiences perceive punishers to have higher moral character when they punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators.

Experiment 3 offers exploratory tests around important contextual features of these punishments: immediacy (how quickly punishers act) and visibility (whether punishment is conducted in public or private). Prior work has suggested that these features impact reputational rewards for prosocial behaviors, including punishments (Bowes-Sperry & O’Leary-Kelly, 2005; Critcher et al., 2013; Engeler & Raihani, 2024; Inesi & Rios, 2023; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Raj & Wiltermuth, 2022). Accordingly, we provide exploratory investigations into whether these contextual attributes shape the reputational rewards for punishing higher- versus lower-power perpetrators.

Scholars have suggested that the immediacy of punishment impacts decisions to punish and evaluations of punishers’ moral character (Engeler & Raihani, 2024; Jordan & Kteily, 2023; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Raj & Wiltermuth, 2022) where delaying signals a calculated consideration of costs and benefits, undermining inferences of altruistic motivations, and therefore, attenuating moral character. We reasoned that perpetrator power might moderate this effect, since punishing higher-power perpetrators incurs extremely high costs, and therefore those who contemplate costs but *still* decide to punish, may be perceived as particularly moral rather than calculating.

We also investigated the effect of visibility – whether the punishment takes place in public versus private. Public punishment signals greater willingness to assume the risks of involvement (Bowes-Sperry & O’Leary-Kelly, 2005; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018), suggesting that it may lead to *greater* moral character ascriptions than private punishment. We reasoned that perpetrator power may moderate this effect, given that costs are especially high when an individual publicly rather than privately confronts a higher-power perpetrator (Mooijman et al., 2015) – and therefore this provides an even more reliable costly signal of their moral character. However, public displays of prosocial behavior are sometimes met with suspicion (De Freitas et al., 2019), with inferences that prosocial actors have selfish intentions. This could actually undermine perceptions of their moral character (Inesi & Rios, 2023). Thus, public punishment may lead to *lower* moral character than private punishment, and this may be consistent across punishing higher- and lower-power perpetrators, instead suggesting that perpetrator power would not moderate this effect.

Method

Participants

We wanted to collect a sufficiently powered sample (power of 0.80 at a significance level of 0.05) to identify a small interaction effect of Cohen’s $f = 0.10$. We determined that a sample of 1,290 would be appropriate, using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009). We recruited 1,433 working adults from Prolific to participate in our experiment. As preregistered, we excluded 118 participants who failed attention checks and were directed out of the experiment before seeing the materials, two participants for failing a comprehension check, and 24 participants for not providing our dependent variables. After exclusions, the final dataset includes 1,289 participants (55.9% women, 43.4% men, 0.7% not disclosed), with an average age of 36.11 ($SD = 11.33$).

Our design was a 2-cell perpetrator power (*higher* versus *lower*) $\times$ 3-cell punishment type (*spontaneous* versus *delayed-private* versus *delayed-public*) between-participants design.

Participants were paid £0.50.

Procedure

We asked participants to imagine they were working as managers in the Human Resources team at a company of about 150 employees. This scenario is adapted from prior work (Inesi et al., 2021). We informed participants that there were 10 individuals on the team, including the Head of Human Resources, three managers (including the participant) and six junior analysts. We included an organizational chart with names displayed for each of these roles. Participants' role in the organization (as one of the three managers) was highlighted.

After completing a comprehension check, we showed participants the same organizational chart as before, with the punisher (Rob, specified as one of the managers) and perpetrator (Sean, specified as the Head of Human Resources in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition, or one of the junior analysts in the *lower*-power perpetrator condition) roles highlighted. In both conditions the punisher was specified to be one of the managers in the organization; and therefore, the punisher was at the same hierarchical level as the participant across conditions. This rules out the possibility that participants may ascribe moral character to punishers differently based on their rank. Next, participants read the following scenario, adapted from Martin et al. (2019):

At the pub one evening, Sean starts gossiping about another employee, sharing private information and making many derogatory comments about this other employee in the process. What Sean doesn't realise is that Rob is actually at the exact same pub, and so Rob overhears Sean's gossip. Neither Rob nor Sean knows the employee that is being gossiped about well.

Participants in the *spontaneous* condition then read:

Rob angrily confronts Sean – his boss [direct report]. He tells Sean that gossiping and spreading private information about people in this way is not OK.

Participants in the *delayed-private* condition instead read:

The next day in the office, Rob waits until he has a one-to-one meeting with Sean. Sean walks into the room and closes the door. Only Rob and Sean are present. Rob angrily confronts Sean – his boss [direct report] – over what happened last night. He tells Sean that gossiping and spreading private information about people in this way is not OK.

Participants in the *delayed-public* condition instead read:

The next day in the office, Rob waits until the whole HR team is together in a meeting. Sean walks into the room and closes the door. Everyone on the HR team is present. Rob angrily confronts Sean – his boss [direct report] – over what happened last night. He tells Sean that gossiping and spreading private information about people in this way is not OK.

After reading the scenario, participants responded to the dependent measures and manipulation checks.

Measures

Manipulation checks. We asked participants how much power they thought Sean (the perpetrator) had in the company, and how much power they thought Rob (the punisher) had in the company (1 = *Very little power*, 5 = *A great deal of power*). We also asked participants the extent to which they agreed that Rob (the punisher) punished Sean (the perpetrator) in public (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly agree*).

Moral character. Participants rated the extent to which Rob (the punisher) possessed eight traits, including: courageous, fair, principled, responsible, trustworthy, just, honest, and loyal (1 = *Not at all*, 9 = *Extremely*). These items are taken from Goodwin and colleagues (2014)

and represent those that are high on morality but lower on warmth, enabling us to focus on the morality element (Goodwin et al., 2014; $\alpha = 0.95$).

Results and Discussion

Manipulation checks

To check whether participants perceived differences in perpetrator power as we intended between conditions, we conducted a mixed ANOVA with perceived power of the punisher and perpetrator as a repeated-measures variable and with perpetrator power condition and punishment type as between-subjects variables. We found significant main effects of perpetrator power condition [$F(1, 1,283) = 1,965.00, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.24$] and punisher/perpetrator [$F(1, 1,283) = 247.35, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.44$]. The interaction between perpetrator power condition and punisher/perpetrator was also significant; $F(1, 1,283) = 4,520.23, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.88$. As expected, participants perceived the perpetrator ($M = 4.53, SD = 0.66$) as having more power than the punisher ($M = 3.36, SD = 0.68$) in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition; $t(1,283) = 36.35, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.43$. Also, as expected, participants perceived the punisher ($M = 3.60, SD = 0.64$) as having more power than the perpetrator ($M = 1.72, SD = 0.67$) in the *lower*-power perpetrator condition; $t(1,283) = 58.78, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 2.32$. Surprisingly, we found that the effect of punishment condition was significant; $F(2, 1,283) = 3.58, p = .028$, Cohen's $f = 0.08$. Follow-up contrasts revealed that participants perceived that actors (i.e., punishers and perpetrators) had more power in the *spontaneous* condition ($M = 3.35, SD = 1.18$) compared to the *delayed-private* condition ($M = 3.28, SD = 1.23$) [$t(1,283) = 2.04, p = .041$, Cohen's $d = 0.08$], and in the *spontaneous* condition compared to the *delayed-public* condition ($M = 3.27, SD = 1.22$) [$t(1,283) = 2.52, p = .012$, Cohen's $d = 0.10$].

To check whether participants perceived differences in private/public punishment as we intended between conditions, we conducted an ANOVA with perpetrator power condition and punishment type as between-subjects variables. We found a significant main effect of punishment condition; $F(2, 1,283) = 758.50, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.09$. As expected, participants perceived that the punisher punished in a more public forum in the *delayed-public* ($M = 3.44, SD = 1.37$) compared to the *delayed-private* condition ($M = 1.35, SD = 0.80$); $t(1,283) = 28.82, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.14$. The *spontaneous* condition ($M = 4.03, SD = 0.96$) was perceived as more public than the *delayed-public* condition [$t(1,283) = 8.11, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.32$] and the *delayed-private* condition [$t(1,283) = 36.99, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.46$], which may have been because the punishment in the *spontaneous* condition took place in a pub rather than a private office. The effect of perpetrator power condition [$F(1, 1,283) = 3.15, p = .076$, Cohen's $f = 0.04$] and the interaction of perpetrator power condition and punishment type [$F(2, 1,283) = 2.49, p = .083$, Cohen's $f = 0.06$] were not significant.

Moral character

We ran an ANOVA with perpetrator power condition, punishment type and their interaction predicting moral character ascriptions. Consistent with our key prediction, we found a significant main effect of perpetrator power condition; $F(1, 1,283) = 69.50, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.23$. Across punishment conditions, participants attributed greater moral character to punishers who punished *higher-* ($M = 7.37, SD = 1.54$) versus *lower-*power perpetrators ($M = 6.65, SD = 1.71$).

We also found a significant main effect of punishment condition; $F(2, 1,283) = 81.21, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.36$. Consistent with extant theorizing on the timing of punishment (Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Raj & Wiltermuth, 2022), participants attributed higher moral character in

the *spontaneous* punishment condition ($M = 7.51$, $SD = 1.37$) compared to both the *delayed-private* punishment condition ($M = 7.27$, $SD = 1.45$) [$t(1,283) = 2.33$, $p = .020$, Cohen's $d = 0.09$] and the *delayed-public* punishment condition ($M = 6.25$, $SD = 1.87$) [$t(1,283) = 12.00$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.47$]. Finally, participants attributed greater moral character to the punisher in the *delayed-private* condition compared to the *delayed-public* condition [$t(1,283) = 9.77$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.38$]. This latter finding may suggest that public punishment is considered a form of shaming and thus communicates lower moral character.

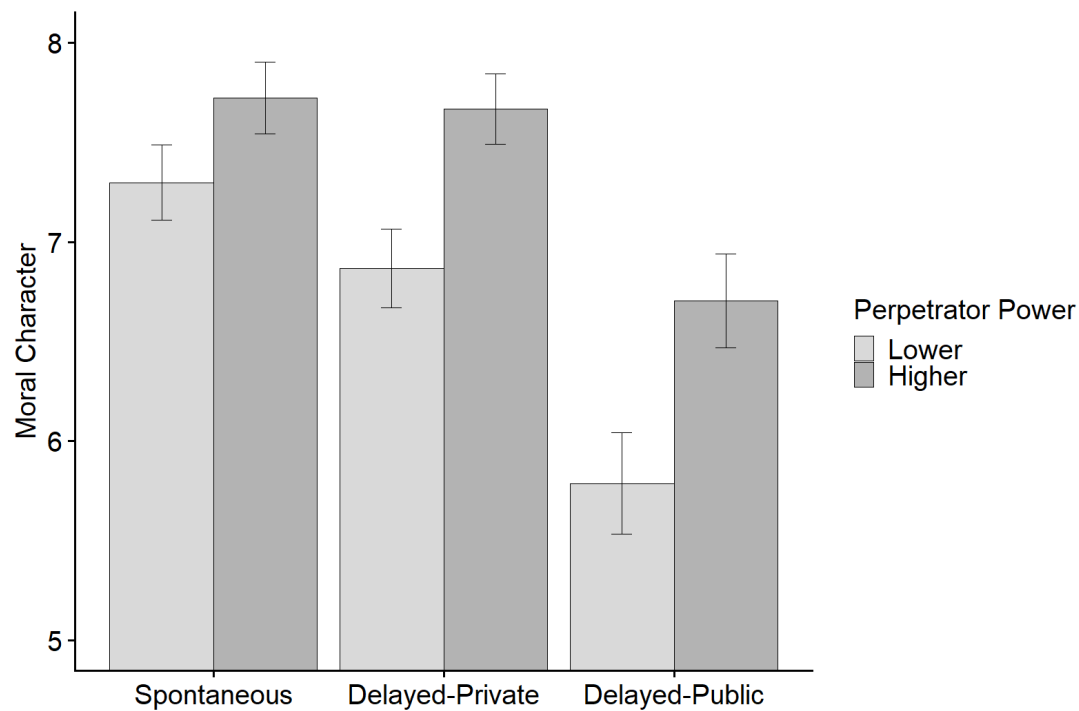
We found a marginally significant interaction between perpetrator power condition and punishment type; $F(2, 1,283) = 2.97$, $p = .052$, Cohen's $f = 0.07$. To better interpret the nature of this interaction, we ran linear regression models to test whether the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character was affected by the visibility (i.e., public versus private) and/or the immediacy (i.e., spontaneous versus delayed) of the punishment.

First, we evaluated whether the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character was affected by the visibility (i.e., public versus private) of the punishment. We regressed moral character onto perpetrator power condition and included a dummy variable that compared the *delayed-private* punishment condition to the *delayed-public* punishment condition, as well as an interaction term (perpetrator power $\times$ dummy). This analysis yielded a non-significant interaction effect ($b = 0.12$, $SE = 0.21$, $p = .580$), which indicated that the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character was equivalent in the *delayed-private* punishment condition and *delayed-public* punishment condition. Thus, we concluded that the visibility (i.e., public versus private) of the punishment did not moderate the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character.

Finally, as an exploratory analysis, we evaluated whether the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character was affected by the immediacy (i.e., spontaneous versus delayed) of the punishment. We regressed moral character onto perpetrator power condition and included a dummy variable that compared the *spontaneous* punishment to the other punishment conditions (i.e., *delayed-private* punishment and *delayed-public* punishment), as well as an interaction term (perpetrator power $\times$ dummy). This analysis yielded a significant interaction effect ($b = -0.43$, $SE = 0.19$, $p = .022$), which indicated that the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character was smaller in the *spontaneous* punishment condition compared to the other two punishment conditions. Thus, we concluded that the immediacy (i.e., spontaneous versus delayed) of the punishment moderated the effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character. See Figure 2 for further details.

Figure 2

The effect of power on perceptions of punishers' moral character (Experiment 3)



Note: Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

These findings extend our broader results in important ways. First, we found further evidence to support our central prediction that audiences ascribe greater moral character to individuals who punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators of unethical behavior.

Second, we found that our central prediction was robust across different experimental contexts. Namely, audiences ascribed greater moral character to punishers who targeted higher- versus lower-power perpetrators – whether the punishment was delayed for a day or occurred spontaneously in the moment. It also emerged whether the punishment was public or private.

At the same time, we found in exploratory analyses that power led to *larger* effects on moral character when punishment was delayed versus spontaneous. In other words, the difference in how moral a punisher was judged to be when punishing a higher- versus lower-

power colleague was greater when the punisher chose to wait before punishing. As we suggested above, this may be because, on the one hand, all those who stop to consider the costs of punishment are seen as having lower moral character (Engeler & Raihani, 2024; Jordan & Kteily, 2023; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Raj & Wiltermuth, 2022), but on the other hand, those who persist in punishing higher-power perpetrators are perceived to do so with full appreciation of the extremely high costs, suggesting that they are highly moral.

Experiment 4a

In Experiment 4a, we sought evidence to support our claim that punishing higher-power perpetrators carries concrete benefits for punishers. Although Experiment 2 demonstrated the effect of power on punisher status, it did not measure moral character as a mediator. We also wanted to measure a different benefit: financial resources through indirect reciprocity. While indirect reciprocity may take different forms – gifts, generous acts, offering help – we test participants' willingness to give financial resources to punishers. This represents a real and externally valid cost to participants who do not know punishers and has been used widely to measure indirect reciprocity in experiments (e.g., Milinski et al., 2002; Simpson & Willer, 2008). We predicted that participants would judge individuals who punished higher- versus lower-power perpetrators as having higher moral character, leading to greater indirect reciprocity.

Method

Participants

We expected to uncover a moderate effect of perpetrator power condition on moral character of Cohen's $d = 0.40$ based on prior experiments, and a small indirect effect of perpetrator power condition on indirect reciprocity through moral character, based on a small pilot experiment. Based on these anticipated effect sizes, we followed the guidance in Fritz &

MacKinnon (2007), and elected for a sample of at least $N = 412$ to ensure power of 0.80 at a significance level of 0.05. To be conservative and account for exclusions, we recruited 558 working adults from Prolific to participate in our experiment. As preregistered, we excluded 63 participants who failed attention checks and were directed out of the experiment before seeing the materials, and we also removed three participants for not providing moral character ratings. After exclusions, the final dataset includes 492 participants (48.2% women, 51.4% men, 0.4% not disclosed). Participants had an average age of 39.70 ($SD = 11.90$). We employed a 2-cell perpetrator power (*higher* versus *lower*) between-participants design. Participants were paid £1.00 in total (including the bonus).

Procedure

We informed participants that they would be reviewing the LinkedIn profile of Mark, a sales coordinator at a lighting solutions company called Acantra Lighting Limited. In reality, we created this LinkedIn profile specifically for the experiment. Before showing participants Mark's LinkedIn profile, we presented them with an organizational chart outlining Mark's position in the sales department. This organizational chart also contained another role at the same level as Mark (another sales coordinator), a role above Mark (Vice President of Sales) and various roles below Mark (interns). These additional roles were used in the later power manipulation.

After showing participants the organizational chart, we revealed Mark's LinkedIn profile to participants. In addition to biographical information, this profile included a Recommendations section, in which another person had posted a story about a time that Mark had observed unethical behavior at work and chosen to punish the perpetrator. We varied between conditions whether the story involved Mark (the punisher) confronting the Vice President of Sales (*higher-*

power perpetrator) or an intern (*lower-power perpetrator*). Participants read the following, which we adapted from a scenario in Martin et al. (2019):

I worked alongside Mark, and one incident in particular stands out. One evening, I was with Mark in the pub, when we overheard our boss (the Vice President of Sales) [an intern] making inappropriate and derogatory remarks about a fellow colleague who was not present. Without hesitation, Mark confronted the Vice President of Sales [intern], firmly expressing that such behaviour was unacceptable.

To ensure that participants read the recommendation, we presented participants with a second screenshot this time, specifically of the recommendation from Mark's LinkedIn profile. After reading the recommendation, we asked participants to provide ratings of the punisher's moral character. After providing these scores, we informed participants that they would play a Dictator Game (Kahneman et al., 1986). They were given 50 British pence, which represented a 100% potential increase on top of their payment (which was also 50 pence). Participants had complete discretion over this additional endowment: they could keep it all or give any amount up to 50 pence to the punisher and keep whatever remained. This is a form of indirect reciprocity, since the participant received nothing from the individual, but may feel inclined to offer resources to them, based on that person's actions (Herne et al., 2013; Inesi et al., 2021; Simpson & Willer, 2008). Furthermore, there was no possibility that the participant would gain something back from the individual. While participants sacrificed relatively small financial amounts in our experiment (i.e., up to a maximum of 50 pence), research has shown that economics games involving comparable amounts in online panels produce similar effects to in-person tasks with ten-fold increases in stakes (Amir et al., 2012; Arechar et al., 2018; Horton et al., 2011). After completing the Dictator Game, participants completed our power manipulation check.

Measures

Manipulation check. We asked participants about the relative power between the punisher and the perpetrator at work ($1 = [\text{punisher}] \text{ has more power than } [\text{perpetrator}]$, $5 = [\text{perpetrator}] \text{ has more power than } [\text{punisher}]$).

Moral character. We used the same nine-item bipolar scale as we used in Experiment 1 (Effron et al., 2015; $\alpha = 0.95$)⁸.

Indirect reciprocity. We measured indirect reciprocity as the amount in pence that participants shared with the punisher during the Dictator Game, consistent with prior research (Herne et al., 2013; Inesi et al., 2021; Simpson & Willer, 2008). The amount shared with the punisher ranged from 0 to 50 pence ($M = 14.77$ pence, $SD = 15.57$).

Results and Discussion

Manipulation check

To check whether participants perceived power differences as intended, we conducted an independent-samples t-test on participants' power ratings of the punisher compared with the perpetrator. Results revealed a significant difference in these power ratings; $t(491) = 63.11$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 5.69$. As expected, participants perceived that the perpetrator had more power relative to the punisher in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition ($M = 4.71$, $SD = 0.69$), compared to the *lower*-power perpetrator condition ($M = 1.22$, $SD = 0.52$).

⁸ We used the moral character scale from Experiment 1 since we conducted Experiment 4a before Experiment 3. However, we note that if we select only those items strictly linked to morality (Goodwin et al., 2014; Dishonest-Honest, Unfair-Fair, Immoral-Moral, Bad-Good), the results remain robust and highly similar.

Moral character

An independent-samples t-test on moral character revealed a significant effect of perpetrator power condition; $t(490) = 3.77, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.34$ ⁹. Supporting our prediction, participants perceived that the punisher had greater moral character in the *higher-* ($M = 5.72, SD = 1.03$) versus the *lower-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 5.36, SD = 1.11$).

Indirect reciprocity

Given that indirect reciprocity was skewed, we conducted a Mann-Whitney U test to assess differences between perpetrator power conditions, which is appropriate when the outcome is not normally distributed. Results indicated that there was a marginally significant difference in indirect reciprocity between perpetrator power conditions ($U = 32,609, z = 1.49, p = .060$).

Participants shared more of their bonus with the punisher in the *higher-* ($M = 16.15$ pence, $SD = 16.43$) versus the *lower-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 13.38$ pence, $SD = 14.57$).

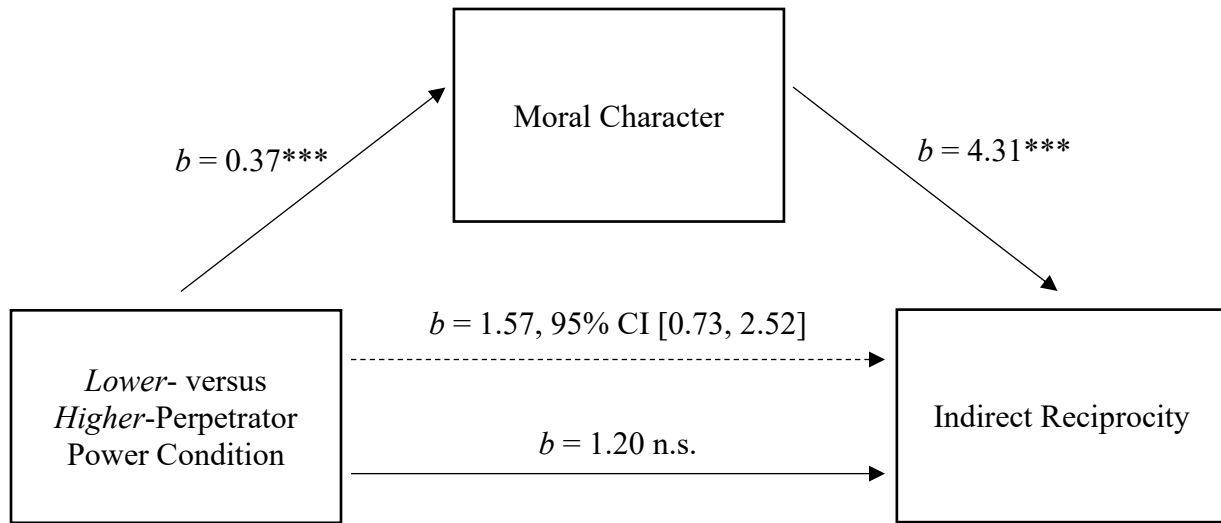
Indirect effect

Lastly, we examined whether the effect of perpetrator power condition on indirect reciprocity was mediated by moral character, using Hayes' PROCESS Macro Model 4 (Hayes, 2017). Using 20,000 bootstrapped samples, there was a significant indirect effect of perpetrator power condition on indirect reciprocity via moral character; $b = 1.57, SE = 0.46, 95\% CI [0.73, 2.52]$. See Figure 3.

⁹ This result was robust using an exploratory independent-samples t-test on a composite of the items most closely related to moral character (i.e., Dishonest-Honest, Unfair-Fair, Immoral-Moral, Bad-Good); $t(490) = 3.88, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.35$.

Figure 3

Results for Hayes Process Model 4 (test of indirect effect; Experiment 4a)



Note. Dashed path represents the indirect effect. *** $p < .001$; n.s. = not significant.

Thus, results from Experiment 4a demonstrate once again that punishing a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator enhances perceptions of moral character. Importantly, we also showed that an implication of this is that audiences are more willing to indirectly reciprocate. These results are especially notable because participants sacrificed their own financial resources to reward punishers, particularly when they punished a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator – knowing that there was no way they would get these resources back. These results go beyond previous experiments, where rewards were conferred by audiences without cost. Here, we demonstrate that audiences financially reward those who punish higher- versus lower-power perpetrators, sacrificing their own resources to do so.

Experiment 4b

In our final experiment, we sought evidence for all steps of our theorizing, namely that perceptions of elevated costs for punishing higher-power perpetrators drive higher ascriptions of

moral character, triggering reputational rewards. We test two consequential reputational rewards not measured in our prior experiments: trust and partner selection. Finally, we test our predictions using a different transgression and confrontation scenario. Instead of confronting a perpetrator for revealing private information (Experiments 3 and 4a), punishers in Experiment 4b reprimanded a colleague who was not doing their share of the team's work.

Method

Participants

Based on a pilot experiment, we predicted to uncover a small indirect effect of perpetrator power condition on trust behavior through costs and moral character. We followed the guidance in Schoemann et al. (2017), and aimed for a sample of $N = 700$ to ensure power of 0.80 at a significance level of 0.05. We recruited 744 working adults from Prolific to participate in our experiment. As preregistered, we excluded 43 participants who failed an attention check and were directed out of the experiment before seeing the materials, 70 participants for answering comprehension checks incorrectly, and 10 participants who expressed doubt over whether the scenario in our experiment was real. After exclusions, the final dataset includes 621 participants (49.4% women, 49.8% men, 0.8% not disclosed). Participants had an average age of 38.47 ($SD = 12.13$). We employed a 2-cell perpetrator power (*higher* versus *lower*) between-participants design. Participants were paid £0.80 in total (including the bonus).

Procedure

We told participants that they would be matched with another participant from Prolific to complete a joint task. To enhance realism, we made participants wait for 10 seconds on a screen with a loading icon, after which we informed them with whom they were matched. In reality, all participants were matched with “Rob H”, a profile we created for the experiment. We told

participants that Rob had already completed his portion of the task the previous week, and then we presented participants with some information about Rob, so that they could get to know him. We told participants that we asked Rob to describe his job and team structure, and an ethical dilemma he recently faced and how he handled it. Participants read the following, ostensibly written by Rob:

I work as a sales associate for a company based in Bristol. I work closely with three people. There's my boss Sean [Pat] who's the Sales Director. Then there are two sales reps, Martin and Pat [Sean] who report to me. There are others on the team, but most of my day-to-day work is with Sean, Martin and Pat [Pat, Martin and Sean].

A few days ago, I was in the office with Sean (my boss) [(my direct report)]. We were due to submit an important proposal to a potential client by the end of the day. As a senior [junior] member of the team, Sean was responsible for doing the final check on the document. The whole team had been working flat-out on it for the previous three weeks, and it was highly likely that the proposal contained some mistakes that needed correcting. At about 6pm, Sean seemed to be in a rush to leave the office. I heard him call someone and tell them he'd meet them at the pub shortly. Then, I saw him print the proposal and put it into an envelope – but I knew he hadn't checked the proposal for mistakes. I went over and angrily confronted Sean. I said that it was not OK to send the project proposal to a potential client without checking it first.

We asked participants to complete three comprehension checks about Rob's job, the name of his boss or direct reports, and the person he punished in the story. Then, we asked participants to indicate the costs Rob faced and infer his moral character.

Next, we informed participants that they would be playing a Trust Game with Rob. We used the same experimental procedure as in Jordan and colleagues' work (Jordan et al., 2016). We endowed participants with 30 pence (a 60% potential increase on top of their payment of 50 pence) and informed them that any amount sent to Rob would be tripled, at which point Rob would decide how much, if anything, to return to them. Participants had complete discretion over how much to transfer to Rob. This game measures trust because participants only share their own

endowment with the other person to the extent that they trust that the person will reciprocate. This measure of trust differs from indirect reciprocity, where resources are freely given with no expectation of future interaction. In the Trust Game, the trustor is vulnerable to the trustee's future actions in the known second round. In this way, it effectively captures the real experience of vulnerability inherent in trust.

After completing the Trust Game, participants indicated their willingness to work with Rob again on this task and answered our power manipulation checks. Finally, we provided participants with a free-response space to provide comments on the experiment, where we excluded any participants that indicated suspicions over whether Rob and the scenario he described was real or not.

Measures

Manipulation check. We asked participants how much power they thought Sean (the perpetrator) had in the company, and how much power they thought Rob (the punisher) had in the company (1 = *Very little power*, 5 = *A great deal of power*).

Costs. We measured costs by asking participants to indicate the feelings of anxiety the punisher would have felt punishing the perpetrator, with a four-item scale: nervous, anxious, worried, and apprehensive (Kouchaki & Desai, 2015; $\alpha = 0.87$).

Moral character. We used the same scale as in Experiment 3, where participants rated the extent to which the punisher possessed eight traits (courageous, fair, principled, responsible, trustworthy, just, honest, and loyal) (1 = *Not at all*, 9 = *Extremely*) (high morality items; Goodwin et al., 2014; $\alpha = 0.94$).

Trust. To maximize external validity, we focused on a behavioral measure of trust that has been used extensively in extant research (The Trust Game; Berg et al., 1995). We measured

trust as the amount in pence that participants shared with the punisher during the Trust Game (Jordan et al., 2016). This amount ranged from 0 pence to 30 pence ($M = 21.27$ pence, $SD = 9.86$).

Partner selection. Lastly, we measured partner selection by asking participants to indicate their willingness to work with the punisher if they were to play the game again (1 = *I would prefer to be matched with a new person*, 7 = *I would prefer to play with Rob H again*).

Results and Discussion

Manipulation check

To check whether participants perceived differences in power as we intended between conditions, we conducted a mixed ANOVA with perceived power of the punisher and perpetrator as a repeated-measures variable and perpetrator power condition as a between-subjects variable. There was a significant main effect of perpetrator power condition [$F(1, 619) = 483.67, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.88$], however the effect of punisher/perpetrator was not significant [$F(1, 619) = 1.47, p = .226$, Cohen's $f = 0.04$]. Importantly, the interaction was significant; $F(1, 619) = 1,248.99, p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.42$. As expected, participants perceived that the perpetrator ($M = 4.66, SD = 0.58$) had more power than the punisher ($M = 3.28, SD = 0.66$) in the *higher*-power perpetrator condition; $t(619) = 24.43, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.39$. The opposite was true in the *lower*-power perpetrator condition [perpetrator power: $M = 2.23, SD = 1.04$; punisher power: $M = 3.71, SD = 0.69$; $t(619) = 25.54, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.45$].

Costs

An independent-samples t-test on costs revealed a significant effect of perpetrator power condition; $t(619) = 7.94, p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.64$. Supporting our prediction, participants

perceived that punishment would be more costly for punishers in the *higher-* ($M = 3.53$, $SD = 0.84$) versus *lower-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 2.93$, $SD = 1.05$).

Moral character

An independent-samples t-test on moral character revealed a significant effect of perpetrator power condition; $t(619) = 6.57$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.53$. Supporting our prediction, participants perceived that the punisher had higher moral character in the *higher-* ($M = 7.63$, $SD = 1.11$) versus the *lower-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 6.96$, $SD = 1.44$).

Trust

Given that trust was skewed, we conducted a Mann-Whitney U test to assess differences between perpetrator power conditions, which is appropriate when the outcome is not normally distributed. Results indicated that there was no difference in trust between perpetrator power conditions ($U = 49,798$, $z = 0.73$, $p = .222$). Participants in the *higher-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 21.74$, $SD = 9.29$) trusted the punisher with similar amounts as participants in the *lower-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 20.78$, $SD = 10.42$).

Partner selection

An independent-samples t-test on partner selection revealed a significant effect of perpetrator power condition; $t(619) = 2.76$, $p = .006$, Cohen's $d = 0.22$. Participants indicated a greater willingness to work with the punisher in the *higher-* ($M = 5.54$, $SD = 1.54$) versus the *lower-*power perpetrator condition ($M = 5.18$, $SD = 1.76$).

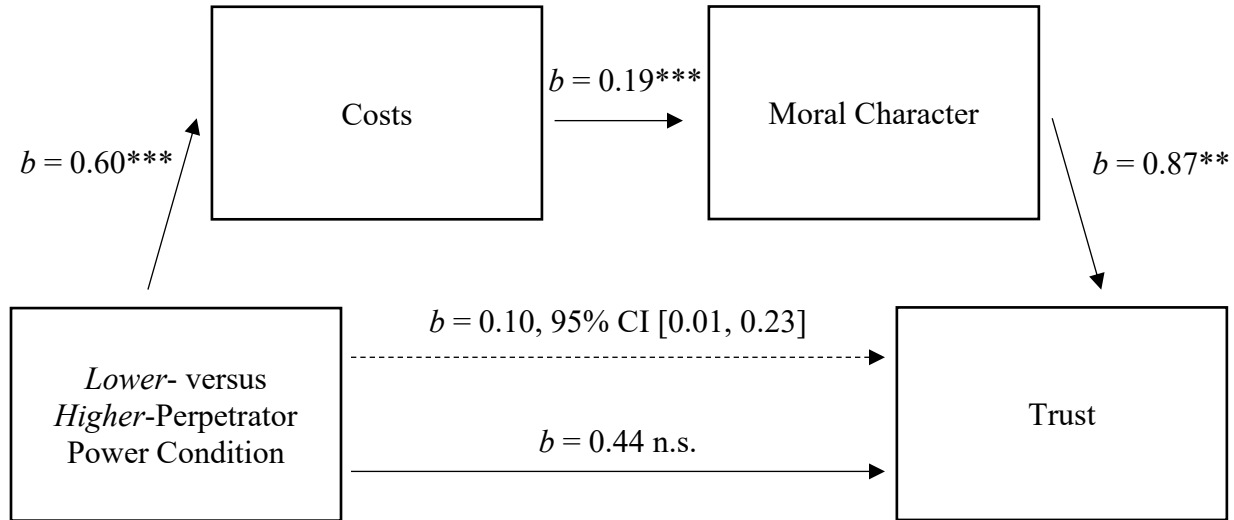
Indirect effects

We examined whether the effect of perpetrator power condition on trust was serially mediated by costs and moral character, using Hayes' PROCESS Macro Model 6 (Hayes, 2017). Using 20,000 bootstrapped samples, there was a significant indirect effect of perpetrator power

condition on trust via costs and moral character; $b = 0.10$, $SE = 0.06$, 95% CI [0.01, 0.23]. See Figure 4.

Figure 4

Results for Hayes Process Model 6 (test of indirect effect; Experiment 4b)

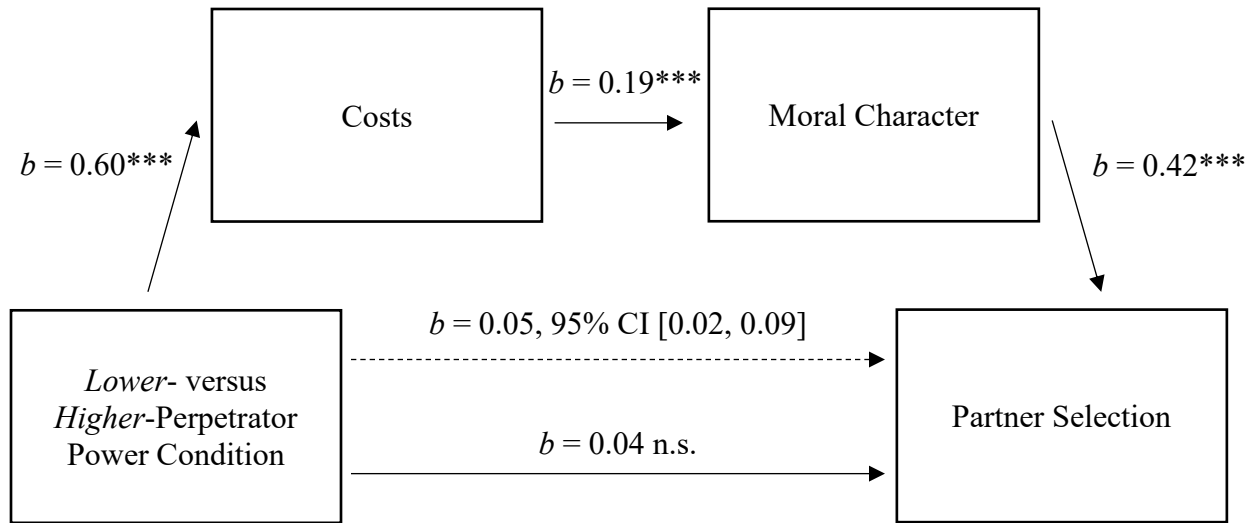


Note. Dashed path represents the indirect effect. *** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$; n.s. = not significant.

Lastly, we examined whether the effect of perpetrator power condition on partner selection was serially mediated by costs and moral character, using Hayes' PROCESS Macro Model 6 (Hayes, 2017). Using 20,000 bootstrapped samples, there was a significant indirect effect of perpetrator power condition on partner selection via costs and moral character; $b = 0.05$, $SE = 0.02$, 95% CI [0.02, 0.09]. See Figure 5.

Figure 5

Results for Hayes Process Model 6 (test of indirect effect; Experiment 4b)



Note. Dashed path represents the indirect effect. *** $p < .001$; n.s. = not significant

Thus, results from Experiment 4b demonstrate that the greater perceived costs involved in punishing a higher- versus lower-power perpetrator lead to higher ascriptions of moral character, which in turn leads to greater trust toward and increased selection of these individuals as partners.

General Discussion

Unethical behavior by power-holders remains a persistent and consequential challenge for social groups. When powerful actors commit wrongdoings, the effects cascade widely – undermining fairness, damaging collective well-being, and eroding trust within social systems. Although punishment has emerged as a successful way of curtailing unethical behavior, it is fraught with risk for punishers, who may face retaliation, backlash, and strained relationships; and these risks magnify when they punish higher-power perpetrators. This suggests an

unfortunate dynamic – people may be most reticent to punish those whose unethical acts are most harmful.

In the present research, we suggest that this is not the whole picture – that a more constructive dynamic occurs in parallel, one that may encourage people to punish higher-power perpetrators. Our findings reveal that those who punish higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators enjoy substantial reputational rewards from their social groups. Our experiments demonstrated that, because audiences expect them to face greater costs, punishers who stand up to higher- (versus lower-) power perpetrators are conferred higher moral character. Importantly, this triggers increased reputational rewards – specifically, greater status, acts of indirect reciprocity, trust, and selection as partners. Taken together, it is possible that, consciously or not, people tend to punish higher-power perpetrators because they expect downstream rewards.

Our findings were obtained from punishments that took place across a variety of contexts and were preceded by multiple types of unethical behavior. In our experiments, we leveraged real punishment scenarios that participants recalled involving people they know and we also developed punishment scenarios involving gossiping and shirking work duties. Since power differences between punishers and perpetrators consistently impacted reputational rewards across such a wide range of punishments – and with such diverse participant pools – we suggest that these effects are robust and widely generalizable.

Theoretical Implications

The present research makes several important contributions. First, while existing literature has identified a series of costs associated with punishing higher-power perpetrators, we believe that we are among the first to highlight concrete benefits. Existing work shows that punishers face higher likelihood of retaliation, negative evaluations, and social exclusion (Czopp

& Monteith, 2003; Gulker et al., 2013; Monin et al., 2008). As a result, prior work has tended to frame punishment – particularly upward punishment – as behavior that is denigrated, discouraged, and avoided (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Molho et al., 2020; Wellman et al., 2016). Our findings complement but extend this perspective. We show that individuals benefit from punishing higher-power perpetrators because they are seen as having higher moral character, which translates into concrete rewards including status, resources, trust, and a greater selection of people to work with. In demonstrating these benefits, our findings suggest why individuals may be motivated to punish the powerful for committing unethical acts. We believe that we are the first to demonstrate that the effect of third-party punishment on reputational rewards is significantly affected by power relationships between punishers and perpetrators.

Second, our work unites disparate literatures that have largely progressed independently. Research on third-party punishment (Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004; Fehr & Gächter, 2002) has considered cooperative benefits for social groups when observers punish perpetrators and has highlighted reputational benefits for punishment in general (Jordan et al., 2016; Nelissen, 2008). In parallel, work on confronting prejudice and moral rebellion has considered the negative consequences for punishers, namely the potential or actual costs incurred, and how these increase when perpetrators have more power than confronters (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Gulker et al., 2013; Monin et al., 2008; Wellman et al., 2016). We integrate these areas of research to make a novel theoretical contribution: because third-party punishing higher-power perpetrators is particularly costly – it carries superior reputational rewards. This suggests that social groups may have a previously unknown, built-in mechanism that encourages the punishment of powerful perpetrators.

Third, these findings contribute to literature that highlights the critical role that power plays in determining how audiences respond to people who act prosocially (Emerson, 1962; Inesi et al., 2021; Kunstman et al., 2018; Vonk, 1998). Much of the research on power considers how holding higher-power positions affects people's behavior (e.g., Galinsky et al., 2008; Gobel et al., 2025; Keltner et al., 2003; Wiltermuth & Flynn, 2013). In contrast, earlier work considered the effects of power as a social cue that guides audiences' judgments of others' behavior. For example, Jones (1964) theorized that power differences create perceptions that subordinates are ingratiating when they offer help, and Vonk (1998) found that those who frequently compliment bosses are seen as "slimy" (see also Inesi et al., 2021). This work demonstrates that audiences leverage power to generate attributions for why actors behave prosocially (Le Pargneux & Cushman, 2025). In this prior work, power relationships generate suspicion that prosocial actors are selfishly motivated, undermining the perceived morality of their behavior. However, our work shows that power can have the opposite effect – instead of fostering suspicion, power enables audiences to distinguish more costly punishments from less costly ones and therefore confer greater reputational rewards. We tested this directly in *Supplemental Study 2*, where we uncovered a significant interaction of prosocial action (i.e., help versus punishment) and perpetrator power on moral character. Thus, the present research broadens our understanding of why power relationships matter in judgments of prosocial behaviors, extending this to punishment. Fundamentally, it shows that audiences are sophisticated and flexible in their use of power relationships to enhance their understanding of the morality behind prosocial behaviors.

Future Directions

In the current set of experiments, we focused on audience reactions to punishment involving actors with unequal power relationships; however, individuals might also punish

laterally, i.e., targeting those with equal power to their own. Recent work suggests that psychological states associated with equal-power relationships may be substantively different from those in unequal-power relationships, and therefore in many contexts, equal-power psychological states may not represent a midpoint between higher- and lower-power psychological states (Schaerer et al., 2018, 2021). Thus, we excluded equal-power conditions from our experiments, because including them may have introduced considerable noise and variability; and this investigation was beyond the scope of the present research. However, we suggest that future research considers whether and why audience reactions to lateral punishments differ from their reactions to upward and downward punishments.

An exciting future direction is to investigate how these dynamics affect the stability of social hierarchies. In general, social hierarchies tend to be stable, with built-in reinforcement mechanisms (Magee & Galinsky, 2008). For example, members of demographic groups that have historically held status are more likely to earn status absent objective information about inherent qualities (Ridgeway et al., 1985). However, there is growing literature that considers when and how hierarchies change (Marr & Thau, 2014; Pettit & Marr, 2020). Our work suggests a mechanism that produces changes in hierarchies – when power-holders engage in counter-normative behaviors and observers punish. Thus, future work could examine whether the status conferred on upward punishers translates into permanent changes in the social hierarchy; and whether these dynamics precipitate changes in power structures. If true, it may suggest a functional pattern within social groups that disrupts the social hierarchy when those at the top act against the group's interests, by realigning power and status toward those who behave prosocially and congruently with the group's interests (Maner, 2017; Maner & Case, 2016; Maner & Mead, 2010). Relatedly, it would be interesting to consider whether the status gains

that emerge from punishment are aligned with prestige or dominance tactics. Research on gaining hierarchical rank suggests two strategies: dominance (use of force to induce fear) and prestige (contributing expertise to gain respect and admiration; Cheng et al., 2013). Punishing higher-power perpetrators may combine both strategies: inducing fear but also building prestige through providing benefits (Maner, 2017; Maner & Case, 2016; Redhead et al., 2021). Further work should examine whether individuals who gain rank through these punishments do so through the prestige or dominance pathways (or both).

We also suggest that future research considers the extent to which punishers are aware of reputational rewards, contingent on power dynamics and the situational context, and how this shapes behavior. In *Supplemental Study 3*, we found that participants were aware that they build stronger moral reputations by punishing higher- versus lower-power perpetrators. This complements earlier work that has shown that punishers understand that these punishments elicit greater retaliation (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Molho et al., 2020). However, further work should build on these findings and assess whether individuals punish more when these reputational opportunities arise (Maner, 2017; Maner & Case, 2016). Indeed, recent work finds that people are more likely to help lower-power victims when in public versus in private, likely because they believe it is more effective in building their moral reputation (Inesi & Rios, 2023). A similar story could emerge with punishment, such that people are more likely to punish higher-power transgressors when their punishment will be known to others and thus build their reputation (Kurzban et al., 2007; Piazza & Bering, 2008).

Constraints on Generality

We conducted our experiments with online panels using participants from the United Kingdom, thus, our results may not generalize to other populations, particularly with different cultural norms surrounding punishment, power, and morality.

We found consistently strong evidence of the reputational rewards of third-party punishing power-holders through experiments that included diverse types of transgressions, however, we only operationalized third-party punishment as the direct confrontation of transgressors, adapting and extending paradigms from prior research (e.g., Martin et al., 2019). However, punishment may take other forms, e.g., indirect punishment such as gossiping, ostracizing, withholding rewards or refusing to cooperate in future (Balafoutas et al., 2014; Boles et al., 2000; Curtis et al., 2021; Feinberg et al., 2012; Molho et al., 2020) or socially undesirable punishment such as the use of physical violence against perpetrators. Future research should examine whether the format of punishment impacts moral character ascriptions for punishing higher- versus lower-power perpetrators.

Across our experiments, participants read about instances in which third parties punished perpetrators. Some of these were punishments that occurred in real interactions, and others were created using prior experimental paradigms. This is common practice in psychology, in which scenarios are used to simulate real experiences (Martin et al., 2019; Pedersen et al., 2018; Sarin et al., 2021). However, in our work, it offered an additional benefit, in that reading about a punishment is similar to hearing about one through the gossip network. Gossip is a central mechanism through which reputations transmit in social groups (Feinberg et al., 2012, 2014), and thus this process is directly relevant to our proposed reputational process. At the same time, we did not include an experiment where participants observed a third-party punishment in real-

time. Thus, it is possible that the effects we uncovered would not generalize to this context, and we recommend it is explicitly tested in future research.

Conclusion

Our research shows that the implications of punishing unethical power-holders are more nuanced – and more hopeful – than has been suggested in prior work. Although punishing powerful perpetrators is costly for those who act, it also provides a particularly informative signal about their moral character to audiences, who respond by conferring rewards on them. This highlights the dual cost-benefit structure of punishment in hierarchical contexts: the same power asymmetries that intensify the costs of punishing amplify the rewards. This dynamic suggests that it is possible that these rewards incentivize less powerful individuals to intervene when they witness those in positions of power harming others. Thus, by integrating insights from costly signaling theory, third-party punishment, and power, our work helps explain why social groups sometimes succeed at patrolling the powerful.

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